# *Queen Victoria's bathing machine*

This is the bathing machine Queen Victoria used at Osborne, her house by the sea on the Isle of Wight. She first went into the sea from it on 30 July 1847. It is 12 feet long: as long as a small car.

Count them in the pictures: wheels ☐ white steps ☐ curly iron brackets ☐



From the side: the green changing room, the cream veranda and the big black wheels. · Steve Daniels, 2017, CC BY-SA 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons



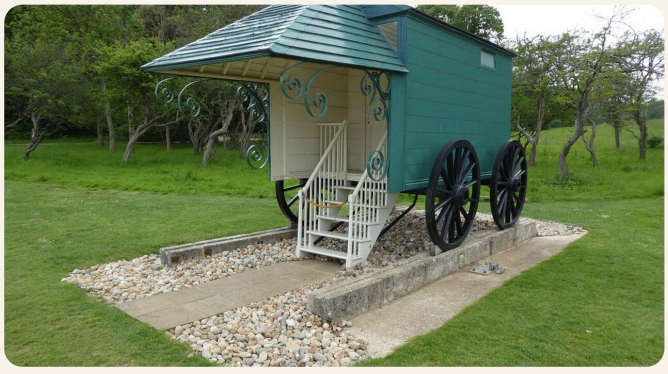
Look up: curly iron brackets hold up the roof over the steps. · grumpylumixuser, 2012, CC BY 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons



From the front: the veranda the Queen stepped out of. · Steve Daniels, 2017, CC BY-SA 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons



The front corner. Can you see the curls of iron? · Steve Daniels, 2017, CC BY-SA 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons



On its long stone bed above Osborne beach. · Roger Cornfoot, 2022, CC BY-SA 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons

# What each part did

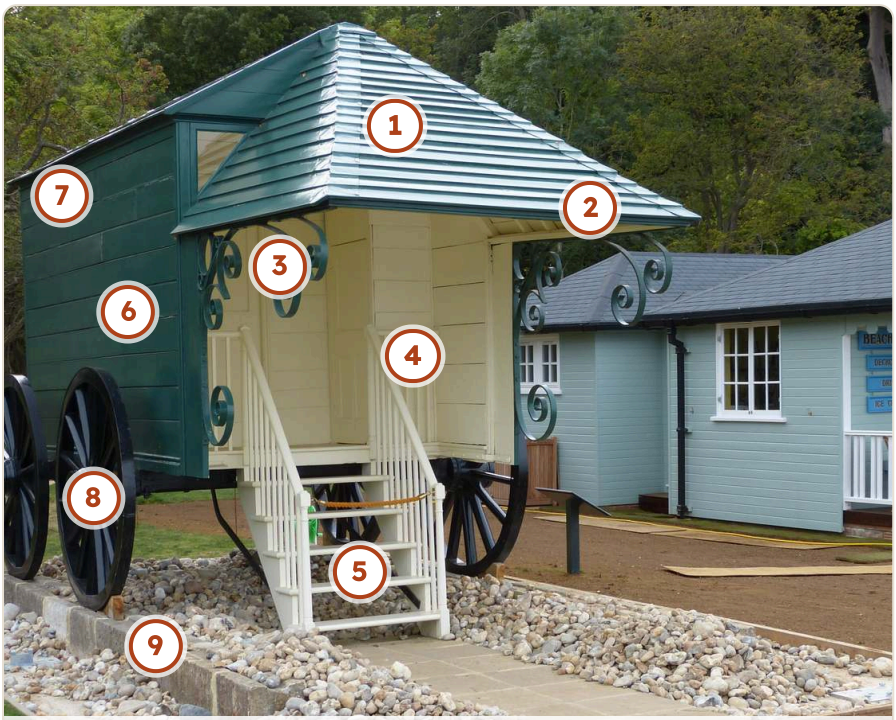



Photo: grumpylumixuser, 2012, CC BY 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons

## Not in the photo

**The winch.** No horse for the Queen. A man turned the handle of a winch, and its wire rope let the machine down the rails into the sea, then wound it back up.

**The dipper.** A strong helper who waited in the water to help bathers in, and sometimes dunked them under.

## Did you know?

Victoria wrote in her diary that her first dip was delightful, until she put her head under the water.

After she died, her bathing machine was used as a hen house! It has been mended, and it stands by the beach at Osborne.

**1 Roof**
It slopes down on all four sides, in overlapping rows, so the rain runs off.

**2 Canopy**
The roof reaches out over the steps, so the Queen kept dry going down them.

**3 Iron brackets**
Curly scrolls of iron, painted green, hold up the canopy.

**4 Veranda**
A little porch at the sea end. The Queen stepped out behind its curtains, so nobody on the beach could see her.

**5 Steps**
Five white steps lead down into the sea. At the bottom of the rails, the lowest ones were under the water.

**6 Changing room**
A little green room where the Queen changed into her bathing dress. Inside was a real toilet with pipes.

**7 Window**
A small window high up lets in the light. The door and window had silver handles.

**8 Wheels**
Four big wheels with flat iron tyres. Each one is about as tall as you are.

**9 Stone rails**
The wheels ran in grooves in stone rails, down a slipway into the sea. Pieces of the rails are still under it.



Ordinary bathing machines, Isle of Wight, 1889. · Henry Pauw van Wieldrecht (Rijksmuseum), 1889, CC0, via Wikimedia Commons



A horse pulling a bathing machine, about 1900. · Knackstedt & Näther (Rijksmuseum), about 1900, CC0, via Wikimedia Commons

### Spot the difference

Most bathing machines were pulled into the sea by a horse. The Queen's ran on stone rails and was let down by a winch. How many wheels has the horse's machine?

Sources: English Heritage, "Five ways to have beach fun like Queen Victoria" (flat iron tyres, changing room, plumbed-in lavatory, curtained veranda, a winch and wire rope); Historic England Archive, IC076/002 (grooved stone rails, winch and cable, first swim 30 July 1847); Emsworth Museum, "Bathing belles and bathing machines" (12 feet long, silver handles, horses); The Victorian Web, "The Queen's bathing machine at Osborne" (her diary, segments of stone rails); History Hit (dippers); Wikipedia, "Bathing machine" (the hen house). Roof, canopy, brackets, window and wheel size are from the photographs.

Name _____ Date _____